

Post-incident review PIR-2025-059

Search Service: intermittent timeouts

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 27 June 2025, Search Service experienced intermittent timeouts in production (Southeast Asia) for about 40 minutes. The error-rate alert paged the on-call engineer. Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

Impact

Users of Search Service saw intermittent timeouts for about 40 minutes. The service owner, Digital Channels, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:15 First signal received.
- 09:24 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:52 Likely cause identified.
- 10:02 Mitigation applied.
- 10:32 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that a feature flag was switched on for every tenant instead of the pilot group.

Capacity dashboards were checked early and showed normal headroom.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

All traffic depended on one component with no standby.

The relevant alert had fired repeatedly the previous week and had been muted by the on-call engineer.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Load test the service at twice the expected peak before the next campaign.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.